

HISTORY

The Printing Press and the Original Information Revolution

Five centuries before the internet, one machine shattered the monopoly on knowledge and reshaped religion, science, and politics. The parallels to our own moment are striking.

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We talk about the digital age as if information revolutions are new. They're not. Around 1440, Johannes Gutenberg combined a few existing technologies into a movable-type printing press — and in doing so triggered upheavals whose pattern looks eerily familiar today.

■ Before: knowledge was scarce by design

In medieval Europe, books were copied by hand, usually by monks. A single Bible could take a scribe years and cost as much as a house. Literacy was rare, and the institutions that controlled the few existing books — chiefly the Church — controlled the flow of ideas. Knowledge was expensive, and whoever owns the means of copying owns the narrative.

■ The machine

Gutenberg's genius wasn't a single invention but a *combination*: movable metal type, oil-based ink, and a press adapted from wine-making. Suddenly a page could be set once and printed hundreds of times. The cost of a book collapsed. Within 50 years, an estimated 20 million volumes had been printed across Europe — more than scribes had produced in the previous thousand years.

■ The earthquakes that followed

Religion. When Martin Luther nailed his 95 Theses in 1517, printers spread them across Germany in weeks. The Reformation was, in large part, the first mass-media event. Ordinary people could finally read scripture themselves rather than rely on intermediaries — and that changed their relationship to authority forever.

Science. Reliable, identical copies meant a researcher in Italy and one in England could reference the *exact same* diagram and data. Knowledge became cumulative and verifiable. The Scientific Revolution rode on the press; without standardized texts, the careful building of one result upon another is nearly impossible.

Language and identity. Printing in local languages — not just Latin — standardized spelling and grammar and helped forge national identities. The book you read shaped the nation you imagined yourself

part of.

■ The dark side, too

It wasn't all enlightenment. The press also spread propaganda, conspiracy, and hate at unprecedented speed. Witch-hunting manuals were bestsellers. The same technology that democratized knowledge also industrialized misinformation. Sound familiar?

■ The pattern that repeats

The printing press shows a template every information revolution seems to follow:

1. A new technology drops the cost of copying ideas to near zero.
2. Old gatekeepers lose their monopoly — and resist.
3. An explosion of both genuine knowledge *and* misinformation follows.
4. Society slowly builds new norms and institutions to cope.

We are living through the same cycle with the internet and now AI. History doesn't repeat, but it rhymes — and the press reminds us that disruption, disorientation, and eventual adaptation are the normal shape of these moments. The printing press took a century to fully reshape the world. We're early in our own version of that story.

What do you think our era's printing press is — the internet, the smartphone, or AI? Make your case below.